service. From this point, the NVA became an all-encompassing force made up of career officers, regular soldiers and conscripts. But as the post-war generation came of age, ‘pacifist views were still widely held,’ Honecker remembered. ‘This was an understandable reaction after the Second World War with its enormous devastation, losses and the crimes committed by the Nazi army.’ Although he insisted it was a peacetime army, training in the NVA was based on Prussian traditions with goose-stepping and endless drilling.

Touring army bases in his shirtsleeves, Honecker endured several testy encounters with unhappy young conscripts. Defending the call-up, he argued that military measures were essentially defensive and ‘all guns were not the same’ – what was most important, he insisted, was who possessed them and for what purpose. ‘We explained the Marxist-Leninist view of wars and armies, the attitude of the working class to the military issue, and the nature of just and unjust wars. We pointed out that the German people and the German working class too had their progressive military traditions.’

Though his opinion did not command unanimous support, he defended a decision to acquire modern armaments including tanks, air defence units with improved anti-aircraft guns, radio equipment and MiG-21 interceptors. This arms bonanza provided an occasion to celebrate on 2 March, when Honecker marked the sixth anniversary of the National People’s Army. Standing rigid on a reviewing stand, he beamed at a tattoo featuring the NVA Music Corps – flanked by torchbearers – marching along Karl-Marx-Allee. In a detailed article, Neues Deutschland witnessed ‘thunderously appreciative’ Berliners enjoy a performance of the international workers’ song ‘Brüder zur Sonne zur Freiheit’. Not everyone was so complimentary. Predictably, Honecker was stung by FRG television commentators who turned a quick, appraising eye at his arms collection and conscription measures. The reports broadcast on the main station, ARD, could be received almost everywhere in the GDR (except in eastern Saxony, which became known as the ‘Tal der Ahnungslesen’, or ‘Valley of the Clueless’, as only state media was available). With the advent of television, night after night, East Germans virtually crossed the border into West Germany eager for information that their own media did not offer, but above all, they sought entertainment and escapism. In response to this nightly defection,